



Singh became the nation's sporting ambassador and was in demand as a patron of major events. At this stage he began to divide his time between athletics and golf. "The latter," he observed, "enjoyed a greater standing on the national sports scene." He continues to play golf regularly but has not given up his interest in athletics. "My most challenging years were as an athlete," he says. "I made my best friends through participation as an athlete, and I always enjoy meeting fellow athletes."

I have pleasant memories of Nairobi in 1984 when Singh and I were asked to carry the Commonwealth Games torch. Massive crowds followed the route right up to our hotel. It would be true to say that no Indian athlete has made as great an impact in athletics as he has.

In 1950s and 1960s, athletics in India was dominated by the army regimental centres, which mass produced outstanding athletes. The army was keen to get the best out of

its stars, so it started sending its leading athletes to England to participate in international competitions. The army athletes, led by Singh, spearheaded a movement through which athletics thrived in the country.

The athletics scenario has undergone a sea change. Now the emphasis is on training rather than competition. To Singh, the picture is somewhat confusing. He misses the crowds at the stadium: "I can understand athletics being taken more seriously than before, but with emphasis on drug taking, the scenario has undergone a change." The competitions have made way for time trials and invitation meets. One would also not mind the collapse of the Berlin Wall—it opened doors to free athletics, but introduced phenomena like drug taking. "There is no joy in competition if it is to be unfair," says Singh. It is something that worries him a lot.

The author taught Maths at St. Stephens and ran the 5,000 m at the 1960 Rome Olympics

Q: Why was Singh so popular at the 1960 Rome Olympics?

A: Because of his long hair and beard, many thought he was a saint who also ran

Q: Who called him the Flying Sikh?

A: Pakistan president Ayub Khan, after he defeated leading athlete Abdul Khalil

Q: For how long was his 400 m national record of 45.6 seconds undefeated?

A: 38 years

Q: How much money did he promise to any athlete who could break his record?

A: Rs 2 lakh

Q: Whom did Singh donate all his medals and trophies to?

A: National Sports Museum at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium, Delhi

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